

CODE OF CONDUCT OF CAPE GIRARDEAU HEMA

This Code of Conduct is adopted by the Board under Section 2.8 of the Bylaws. Part I is adapted from the HEMA Alliance Code of Conduct. Part II is a modern adaptation of the principles of the German fencing master Joachim Meyer. Every member must sign this Code, and signed agreements are kept by the Secretary with the member's waiver.

Scope. This Code applies to all members, Introductory Participants, Responsible Adults, guests, and spectators at every Club practice, event, and activity, including travel to tournaments and other events where a person represents the Club. It also applies in all Club online spaces, group chats, and social media.

PART I — COMMUNITY STANDARDS

Section 1.1. Purpose. The Club is committed to a community that is inclusive and welcoming, open to all, and free from harassment, with clear accountability and fair remedies when that standard is not met.

Section 1.2. Respect and Dignity. Every person shall be treated with respect and dignity. Racist, sexist, homophobic, transphobic, ableist, elitist, or otherwise demeaning attitudes and behavior have no place in the Club.

Section 1.3. Non-Harassment. Harassment of any kind is prohibited, including harassment based on race, color, religion, sex, gender identity, sexual orientation, national origin, age, disability, or any other protected characteristic. Harassment includes offensive language or jokes, and any visual, verbal, written, or physical conduct that would make a reasonable person uncomfortable or interfere with their participation, regardless of intent. It also includes unwanted physical contact outside of agreed training, intimidation, stalking, and photographing or recording a person against their wishes.

Section 1.4. Protection of Minors. Consistent with Section 2.7 of the Bylaws, no adult other than a minor's own Responsible Adult shall be alone with a minor member in a private, unobserved setting. Adults shall not send private electronic messages to minor members; Club communication regarding a minor goes to the Responsible Adult. Training with minors shall take place in open, observable settings.

Section 1.5. Sobriety. No person may train, spar, or instruct while under the influence of alcohol, cannabis, or any other impairing substance.

Section 1.6. Care of Equipment and Space. Members shall treat Club equipment, training sites, and the property of others with care, report damaged or unsafe equipment, and leave every training site as clean as or cleaner than they found it.

Section 1.7. Reporting. Anyone who experiences or witnesses a violation of this Code should report it to any officer or director of the Club. Reports may also be made directly to the HEMA Alliance General Council (gc@hemaalliance.com) or the U.S. Center for SafeSport (uscenterforsafesport.org). Any suspected abuse of a minor must be reported to law enforcement or to the Missouri Child Abuse and Neglect Hotline at 1-800-392-3738.

Section 1.8. Review. The Board shall review every report promptly and keep it as confidential as possible. Any director involved in or with a personal interest in the matter shall not take part in the review, consistent with Section 3.7 of the Bylaws. The person reported shall be given notice and an opportunity to respond as provided in Section 2.5 of the Bylaws, except where immediate action is needed for safety.

Section 1.9. No Retaliation. No one shall retaliate against any person for making a report in good faith or for taking part in a review. Retaliation is itself a violation of this Code.

Section 1.10. Consequences. Depending on the seriousness of the violation, consequences may include a warning, required corrective steps, temporary suspension, or removal from the Club under Section 2.5 of the Bylaws. Violations may also be reported to the HEMA Alliance and, where appropriate, to law enforcement.

PART II — THE MEYER PRINCIPLES

Joachim Meyer was a Freifechter (free fencer) of Strasbourg whose treatise, *Gründtliche Beschreibung der Kunst des Fechtens* (“A Thorough Description of the Art of Fencing”), was printed in 1570. Meyer did not write a formal code of conduct. His treatise does, however, describe what fencing is for and how a fencer should train. Each principle below summarizes Meyer’s teaching and then states what it requires of members today.

Principle 1. Earnest Practice, Not Brawling.

Meyer: Fencing rests on a sound and understandable foundation and must not be confused with foolish showmanship. Wild, thoughtless striking is not fencing but “a foolhardy peasant’s brawl.”

Today: Train with purpose, control, and good technique. Do not swing recklessly, fence to show off, or treat sparring as a fight to hurt someone. Skill, not force, is the goal.

Principle 2. The Agreement Between Fencers.

Meyer: A bout is an exercise in which two fencers contend with the sword under a mutual understanding, each trying to prevail with care, skill, and good form.

Today: Every exchange is an agreement between partners. Agree on the intensity before you begin, respect your partner’s limits, stop immediately when anyone calls “Hold!” or “Halt!” (Bylaws Section 6.5), and honestly acknowledge hits that land on you.

Principle 3. Protect Yourself and Your Partner.

Meyer: Every action has a beginning, a middle, and an end. The end is withdrawing safely: without harm to the opponent if possible, and without injury to yourself.

Today: Your partner’s safety is as important as winning the exchange. Use controlled force, wear required protective equipment (Bylaws Section 6.7), and never leave yourself or your partner exposed to unnecessary risk.

Principle 4. Diligence and Discipline.

Meyer: Meyer called on young fencers to be diligent and disciplined, to practice the art with honorable seriousness, and to conduct themselves with good manners.

Today: Attend training regularly, master the fundamentals before advancing (Bylaws Section 6.6), accept correction from instructors, and conduct yourself with courtesy on and off the floor.

Principle 5. Honest and Thorough Study.

Meyer: Meyer wrote so that the terms and teachings of the old masters could be clearly explained and properly understood, and so that experienced fencers could see that the art rests on a true foundation.

Today: Study the historical sources honestly and thoroughly. Admit what you do not know, credit your sources and teachers, and respect members and other clubs who interpret the sources differently.

Principle 6. Patience with New Students.

Meyer: Meyer explained his terms carefully so that young people coming to the art would not be confused by unfamiliar words or come to look down on the art.

Today: Welcome newcomers, explain clearly, and set a good example for younger members. Every experienced fencer was once a beginner.

Principle 7. Courage and Self-Control.

Meyer: Fencing practice makes a person more courageous, more skilled, and more careful in protecting themselves when it truly matters.

Today: Build fitness, confidence, and composure through training. Use your skills only for training, sport, and lawful self-defense, and never to threaten or intimidate anyone.

Principle 8. Honor in Victory and Defeat.

Meyer: Meyer treated fencing as a knightly art, valued by experienced warriors since the time of the Romans.

Today: Win graciously and lose with dignity. Do not argue with judges or belittle opponents. Remember that at tournaments and in public you represent Cape Girardeau HEMA.

PART III — AGREEMENT

I have read and understand the Cape Girardeau HEMA Code of Conduct. I agree to follow it at all Club practices, events, and activities, and I understand that violations may result in suspension or removal from the Club.

Member Name (printed)

Member Signature

Date

For members under 18:

Parent or Legal Guardian Name (printed)

Parent or Legal Guardian Signature

Responsible Adult Name (if different from above)

Responsible Adult Signature

Date

Adopted by the Board this ____ day of _____, 20__.

President

Secretary